

SC taskforce on student suicides: A good first step

The Supreme Court's **decision** this week to **set up** a task force to **address** the **alarmingly** high rate of student suicides in the country **is** an **acknowledgement** of a crisis. The statistics speak of a system failing its most **vulnerable**. According to the most recent NCRB data, there were over 13,000 student suicides in 2022. As the Court noted, they're a "**grim** reminder" of how inadequate and ineffective **existing frameworks** have been in addressing the mental health concerns of students, and **point to** the need for a more "**robust, comprehensive** and responsive **mechanism** to address the various factors" that **drive** students to the final, **irrevocable** step.

That the court has not turned its eyes away from a problem that only seems to worsen — a 70 per cent increase in the last **decade** — **is** welcome. However, **the task force**, which is to be headed by former Supreme Court Justice Ravindra Bhat, **is** not the solution; it is **merely** one step towards addressing the challenge. **Its work**, which will include representatives from various fields, **could shed** much-needed light on what remains a little understood problem. It has been mandated with drawing up a report on a range of factors that **lead to** student suicides, including academic pressure, **ragging**, sexual harassment, financial burden, mental health **stigma** and discrimination based on caste, gender, **ethnicity, sexual orientation**. It will also **carry out** an assessment of existing frameworks and measures, and make recommendations.

But **the larger picture** of student well-being **calls** for the participation of all **stakeholders: Parents and teachers** who, with **vigilance** and **compassion**, **must shepherd** the young through the tough phases of life, **instilling** the understanding that there is life beyond a failed test; educational institutions that must invest in their students' welfare and staff that is trained to identify the **red flags**. The government, too, must **make good** on the promise of initiatives like the National Education Policy 2020, which emphasises student well-being and mental health, by prioritising reform that focuses on **nurturing** individual **potential**, rather than a **one-size-fits-all** model. Crucially, there needs to be a **concerted** effort to replace the hyper-competitiveness that characterises student life with a genuine love for knowledge, where **curiosity**, rather than **rote learning**, **is** rewarded. The Supreme Court's initiative is a beginning, but results will only come from the **sustained** and **collaborative** action of all stakeholders.

[Practice exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

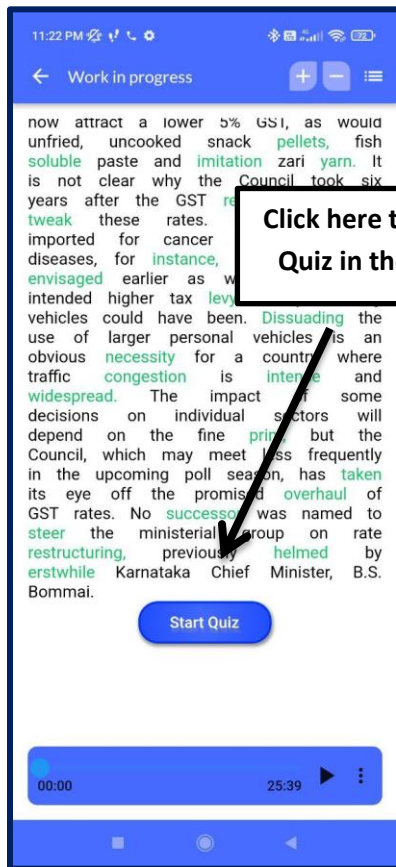
1. **Set up** (phrasal verb) – Establish, Create, Form, Institute, Launch स्थापित करना
2. **Address** (verb) – Tackle, Handle, Confront, Deal with, Manage सुलझाना, निपटाना
3. **Alarming** (adverb) – Worrisomely, Disturbingly, Shockingly, Frighteningly, Troublingly चिंताजनक रूप से
4. **Acknowledgment** (noun) – Recognition, Admission, Acceptance, Confirmation, Appreciation स्वीकृति
5. **The Vulnerable** (noun) – It refers to students who are most at risk or susceptible to harm.
6. **Grim** (adjective) – Bleak, Dismal, Dire, Stern, Harsh भयावह
7. **Existing** (adjective) – Current, Present, Prevailing, Ongoing, Established मौजूदा
8. **Framework** (noun) – Structure, System, Outline, Blueprint, Skeleton ढांचा
9. **Point to** (phrasal verb) – Indicate, Suggest, Highlight, Show, Signal इंगित करना
10. **Robust** (adjective) – Strong, Sturdy, Vigorous, Resilient, Durable मजबूत
11. **Comprehensive** (adjective) – Thorough, Complete, Exhaustive, Inclusive, Extensive व्यापक
12. **Mechanism** (noun) – System, Process, Procedure, Method, Apparatus तंत्र
13. **Drive** (verb) – Force, Push, Compel, Motivate, Propel प्रेरित करना
14. **Irrevocable** (adjective) – Irreversible, Unchangeable, Final, Permanent, Binding अटल
15. **Decade** (noun) – Period of Ten years दशक
16. **Merely** (adverb) – Only, Simply, Just, Barely, Solely केवल
17. **Shed** (verb) – Cast, Spread, Emit, Radiate, Throw (प्रकाश) डालना
18. **Lead (to)** (verb) – Result in, Cause, Bring about, Produce, Generate वजह बनना
19. **Ragging** (noun) – It involves abuse, humiliation, or harassment of new entrants or junior students by the senior students
20. **Stigma** (noun) – Shame, Disgrace, Dishonor, Mark, Blemish कलंक
21. **Ethnicity** (noun) – the quality or fact of belonging to a population group or subgroup made up of people who share a common cultural background or descent. जातीयता
22. **Sexual orientation** (noun) – a person's identity in relation to the gender or genders to which they are sexually attracted; the fact of being heterosexual, homosexual, etc.

23. **Carry out** (phrasal verb) – Execute, Implement, Perform, Conduct, Accomplish
पूरा करना
24. **Stakeholder** (noun) – Participant, Shareholder, Investor, Party, Contributor
हितधारक
25. **Vigilance** (noun) – Alertness, Watchfulness, Caution, Attention, Carefulness सतर्कता
26. **Compassion** (noun) – Empathy, Sympathy, Kindness, Understanding, Mercy करुणा
27. **Shepherd** (verb) – Guide, Lead, Direct, Escort, Nurture मार्गदर्शन करना
28. **Instill** (verb) – Implant, Inculcate, Impart, Infuse, Inspire बिठाना
29. **Red flag** (noun) – Warning sign, Alert, Danger signal, Caution, Alarm चेतावनी संकेत
30. **Make good** (phrase) – Fulfill, Honor, Redeem, Compensate, Achieve पूरा करना
31. **Nurture** (verb) – Foster, Cultivate, Encourage, Support, Develop पालन-पोषण करना
32. **Potential** (noun) – Ability, capacity, possibility, capability सामर्थ्य
33. **One-size-fits-all** (adjective) – suitable for or used in all circumstances.
34. **Concerted** (adjective) – Coordinated, Collaborative, Joint, United, Combined संगठित
35. **Rote learning** (noun) – learning something in order to be able to repeat it from memory, rather than in order to understand it रटत विद्या
36. **Sustained** (adjective) – Continuous, Prolonged, Persistent, Steady, Maintained निरंतर
37. **Collaborative** (adjective) – Cooperative, Joint, Collective, Team-based, Combined सहयोगात्मक

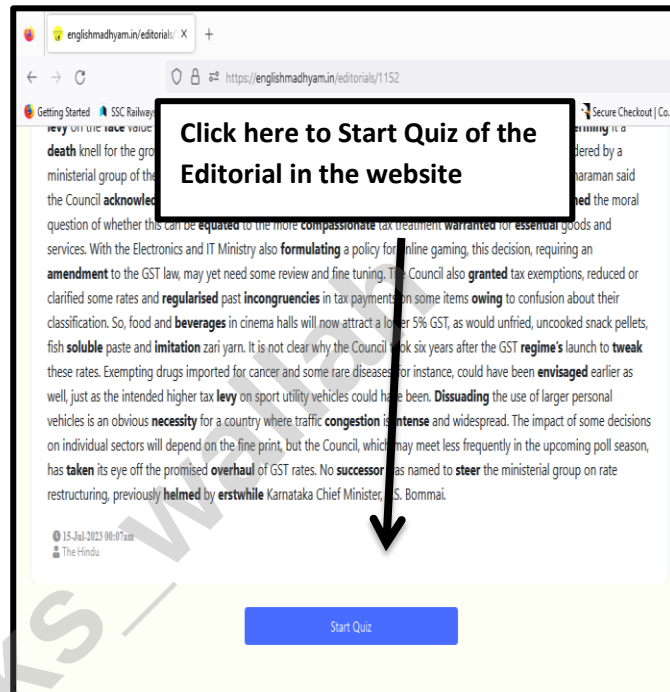
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Crisis Recognition:** The Supreme Court's task force acknowledges India's alarming student suicide crisis (13,000+ cases in 2022, per NCRB).
2. **Systemic Failure:** Current frameworks are inadequate in tackling student mental health issues, necessitating urgent intervention.
3. **Task Force Mandate:** Headed by ex-SC Justice Ravindra Bhat, it will analyze causes (academic pressure, ragging, discrimination, etc.) and evaluate existing measures.
4. **Holistic Inquiry:** The panel includes multi-sector experts to address poorly understood triggers like caste/gender bias and financial stress.
5. **Decadal Surge:** Student suicides rose 70% in 10 years, underscoring the urgency of action.
6. **Limited Solution:** The task force is a preliminary step, not a fix; sustained efforts are needed.
7. **Stakeholder Role:** Parents/teachers must guide youth compassionately, emphasizing resilience beyond academic failures.
8. **Institutional Duty:** Schools/colleges must prioritize welfare, with staff trained to spot mental health red flags.
9. **Policy Implementation:** Govt must deliver on NEP 2020's mental health focus, moving from rote-learning to nurturing potential.
10. **Curiosity Over Competition:** Education must reward curiosity, not hyper-competitiveness that fuels distress.
11. **Structural Reforms:** Recommendations may include systemic changes like reduced academic pressure and anti-discrimination measures.
12. **Mental Health Stigma:** The task force will address societal barriers to seeking help.
13. **Collaborative Approach:** Solutions require coordination among judiciary, educators, parents, and policymakers.
14. **Preventive Focus:** Emphasis on early intervention rather than reactive measures.
15. **Long-Term Vision:** Court's initiative is a start, but success depends on persistent, collective action.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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